“Ocean”

“We are like islands in the sea, separate on the surface but connected in the deep.”

-William James

Maxwell Ken

When we die, all that separates us from when we were born is what we remember.

“Attention passengers, we are now approaching SuperUnion Station of the Canada District. Please ensure you have all your belongings before you disembark. The next destination is the Russia District. Thank you for travelling with Geopolis Railway.”

As the maglev train glided to an orderly, graceful halt at the station, I gazed out the window with a million others, mesmerized by the perpetual metropolis limited only by the extent of our vision. All at once, when the doors on one side opened, we descended from the train in successive queues, congested at the exit and swarmed by our replacements, packed on the bustling platform the length of an Old Earth continent’s coastline.

When I dared to get a glimpse against the expansive Crowd, the vast view of my destination opened up before me: the Canada District. Although the sun’s remaining light cast an ethereal glow on the high-rise skyline, it was reasonably late in the evening. I thought about my routine when I got home: unpack my lunch bag, shower, do some dishes, make dinner, pack the leftovers for lunch again, and sleep before I regretted not doing it earlier during work the next day. I found this imperative; the trip to the USA District, where the offices of the Arcalane megacorporation resided, was just as long as the return home. A little less than an hour.

The platform of this station, already a number of stories high only the architect of this building knew, still required me to take a journeying ascent on a maglev elevator, travelling thirty-six more stories to reach my apartment. I was accompanied by the likes of men and women in business suits, old ladies with canes, children holding the hands of their mothers, young adults with eyes glued to screens, and a myriad of other lively or dismal individuals. Yet regrettably, in my view, they danced as a monolithic mass, and these details made no difference.

The walk to the elevator was one I knew too well. I moved as one with the populace, slow and dull, as we crossed catwalks overlooking menacing alleys threatened by dense jungles of power lines, glass atriums of malls with thousands of stores attracting us with the strongest lights, and digital billboards that temporarily replaced our horizon, making us seem like ants crawling against the backdrop of pixels.

When nightfall arrived and the innumerable neon lights replaced the stars, it began to rain. It was perfectly on time today. As if an army on command, we uniformly opened our black umbrellas, raising them above us. There had once been a time when companies competed with vibrant individual designs, but nowadays it seemed no one cared enough to express themselves against the wave of the same cheap, black models from the most well-known umbrella manufacturing corporation.

Finally, nestled between a handful of passengers more than an Old Earth elevator was designed to carry, I heard the comforting hum of the magnetic machinery as we suddenly soared into the sky, lifted to heights above heavens. The full splendour of the city was revealed. As usual, some children gasped. With enough time, as they saw the same view day after day, they would stop. It would become as stale for them as it was for the adults.

When I glanced myself, I saw reckless ambition and glorious achievement, scattered voices and conduits for endless traffic, evident power yet no hopes and dreams. I saw the lines and arrays of numberless unyielding people, tailing the streaks of dim glow from the lights of the night.

I can't find you here, darling. I don't know where to start. There's an impossible number of possible bodies you could be, as many as the sparkling grains of sand on Earth.

#

Dr. Mei said, "All anyone wants is the resolution of uncertainty."

I had spent the last hour brewing our daily morning black tea, sorting and hole punching paperwork, and setting up the parameters of the software for our new project's experiments. Now, as we settled into the quiet hum of the lab, we were ready to dive into the composition of our evolving theory.

"That's how the pioneers of information theory defined it," I replied. "Information is simply the resolution of uncertainty."

She nodded. "Ideally, the world is readable. Anything can be composed of a string of 1s and 0s, a true or false, which are the smallest units of information. But the universe does its best to scatter information with channels of noise, and so we try to give a rigorous mathematical foundation to efficiently encode, transmit, and store the content of messages against the noise of the universe."

Books could be destroyed, languages could change, and the states of transistors could be corrupted. It was an obvious concept. Even children learned from a young age that all attempts at recordkeeping were temporary, vulnerable—human.

Dr. Mei scribbled notes in her notebook, presumably axioms that we would start with. Arcalane lab equipment was expensive, easily clearing billions of dollars. But Dr. Mei liked using traditional pen and paper. When I asked her why, she always gave vague answers about its superiority. But I doubted her beliefs—how efficient could matter truly be at preserving information versus all other methods?

The first few weeks were slow. We buried ourselves in heavy research, fueled by endless cups of tea and hours spent chasing elusive connections in states of deep concentration. We ran experiment after experiment attempting to entangle qubits. Dr. Mei's initial idea was to entangle particles, not in the classical way, but *temporally*. She believed information could achieve nonlocality, that it was possible to relay information to the past. But we would have no way to find out if the people of the past got our message. Regardless, she wanted to try it.

"The spins of entangled qubits don't matter on their own," she said. "They only matter in relation to each other. One affects the other, no exceptions."

About five to six centuries ago, quantum mechanics researchers discovered how to choose qubit states before measurement, resolving the uncertainty about their randomness and ensuring they could be intentionally controlled for communication. Arcalane was now at the forefront of the field, exploring how to manipulate them independent of time.

"Well, why is what we're doing even important?" I asked Dr. Mei one day.

After a pause, she met my gaze and smiled faintly, as if expecting the question all along.

"Were you taught what happened to the Old Internet at school?"

Everyone was. "Of course."

"Even though nothing there is particularly useful anymore, some days I need to go there to find something in their archives. The digiarchs rule every corner of that place. The Arbiter rules certain sections, the Monarch commands others, the other lesser ones have claimed their pieces of land, and our human forces have ceded all our territories long ago. On some days, I see entire

conversations without a single person. We can't let that happen again, or we'd experience another Great Blackout on our temporary human intranet. If we could come up with a system that lets us rely on what's real and what isn't, we'd transcend this city above its post-truth state, and preserve the information out of chaos."

The room felt colder. I stood, gathering my papers. "Then we keep pushing, no matter how uncertain the path."

"That's all we can do. I'm drafting a new set of parameters tonight. Tomorrow, we try again."

#

One of my earliest memories was waking up not knowing who I was or where I was. I was in bed, and an alarm clock beeped on a bedside table. The air was still and sterile, having been recycled by the vents. A dim hololamp faintly lit the room, and a breakfast-prep machine—Daystarter Series 9—hummed a digital tune downstairs to tell me it was ready. I cautiously regained consciousness in a room that didn't breathe, and my body felt useless as if it had been drowning for years, and now I was moving its stiff muscles again.

I didn't know what happened then. Over time, things became more familiar to me. I found my ID, where I worked, and what maglev rail I took to get there. Dr. Mei was the first one to understand my situation at work, and she helped me reintegrate as Maxwell Ken. But she had been stoic about it. She claimed to know what had happened to me, but wouldn't give any explanation. I didn't hold it against her. I was just glad to have someone who knew who I was in the Crowd. Without her, I wouldn't have survived.

"You had a Great Dream," she called it. "I can't explain any more. But try to get everything about your old life back. It might be important."

There are fragments that surface now and then, sharp and specific. The world had gone dark, and everything had dissolved like ink in water, but one memory clung like a gold leaf to the surface of my mind, held in place by the weight of emotion.

"Today's lesson is about solid-liquid equilibria."

Grade 11 chemistry class. The class watched as she drew a beaker on the chalkboard with a horizontal line to represent the liquid level, then rapidly dotted the inside for the pieces of salt.

"First, we have to understand what *saturation* is. Saturation refers to a state where a solution has reached its maximum capacity for a particular substance, meaning no more solute can be dissolved by the solvent. For example, at 25 degrees Celsius, the solubility of NaCl, or salt, is about 357 grams per litre. That's the maximum amount that can dissolve in the water."

The class was silent as everyone recorded notes on their Aegis pads.

Someone raised their hand. "If you keep adding more, what happens to the extra salt?"

The teacher stopped drawing on the chalkboard and turned to face her.

"That's a good question. You can put more salt in the water, but it won't dissolve anymore. The water will be saturated, meaning the extra salt crystals will remain visible. But they'll drift aimlessly around the water until they stay at the bottom."

#

I felt the bodies of billions when I shopped in a grocery store as large as an Old Earth city, spent three hours to find a username that had not been used, saw walls of graffiti of artist tags overlapping each other over the years, found restaurant reservation schedules with the earliest slot in the next decade, or discovered every patch of grass in the park had withered from excessive foot traffic along the same repeated paths.

From orbit, the planet no longer showed oceans or forests—only endless grids of light and

motion. Towers rose in tessellated patterns across every continent, stitched together by the interdistrict maglev railways and interlaced with power and maintenance trenches the width of Old Earth rivers. No part of the surface remained untouched; every meter had been claimed, engineered, or repurposed. The city had long since stopped growing outward. It grew inward now, dense and recursive, layer after layer. Skyscrapers had foundations that reached the bottom of the sea. I always wondered: What did the fish swimming around the pillars, if there were any left, think about the colossal platforms above them that now blocked the light of their heavens?

Residential areas were infinitely densely packed. The overabundance of food removed traditional human goals and motivations. Everything was replicated or improved upon endlessly, and the individual efforts of most people's life's work amounted to nothing. Attention was currency, and those who held most of it had wealth. Businesses fiercely competed to grab a minuscule piece of the pie, leading to the noise that Dr. Mei wanted to find a solution to. Everyone was suffering in isolation, like the entire population was adrift together in sheer scale and sameness. Purpose was the rarest resource of all, and only the most dedicated elite of the city bore a trace of it. Love was extinct.

"I think it's best if we part ways."

That's what the woman I had split up with said. For a thousand days, we owned each other's hearts. She had long, dark hair, but I've long forgotten her name.

"I want to see other people. I have nothing against you, but when I look online, there are just so many good options. Too many. Even though you're a good man, I don't think I'm ready to commit to just you."

I didn't tell her then, but the feeling was mutual. We had a connection, but how could I be sure it was the best possible connection I could make? When the beautiful women I see online who beg for my attention are limitless, I have no choice but to yield to my heart's wishes for them, to search for the most impeccable one.

When our dinner ended, before we parted ways, I remember telling her: "Don't worry, I'm sure the next one you meet will be the one."

I knew it wouldn't be true. We are all wind-blown leaves, carried by currents of air from one destination to the next, letting schools and jobs dictate our lives with the promise of opportunity. What will happen is she will have a chance encounter and find that person, think they're flawless, and have the best time of her life as she had with me, but once it's over, she'll search for her next option, her next elation, always higher than the next.

I'll be doing the same.

#

"Are you here for the amputation or the thought erasure?"

I waited, unsure of what to say.

The receptionist looked up from her terminal, tilted her head, and smiled. "Oh. I see it now. You're scheduled for a general appointment with Dr. Verma. *Maxwell Ken.* That's an unusual name. I've seen a Kenneth Maxwell and a Ken Makino, but never a Maxwell Ken. It could also be a confused romanization of a Chinese name, lost in translation? That's how it is these days."

She said it with the confidence of someone used to explaining things no one asked about, and with a little grin that highlighted her eyes. Then she coughed and turned red, tucking a loose strand of hair behind her ear. "Sorry. My mother's an *anthroponymist,* a person who studies the history of names. She's interested in how the repeated transliteration of names causes the originals to become lost to time. Sometimes I ramble."

"It's fine," I said, and sheepishly laughed. I never gave it much thought. After my Great

Dream, I couldn't tell her where it came from, even if I wanted to.

"Just go to Room 5, up ahead. Thanks."

I gave her a polite nod and followed the corridor until I reached the room. Dr. Verma was already waiting inside.

"What is it *this* time?" he joked.

"Seems like I'm going to be seeing you often."

He nodded. "After an extensive analysis of the symptoms you listed from your last visit, I've reached a proper diagnosis for what you're experiencing. It's called Narrative Overload Syndrome. Lately, the medical field has been researching to see if it's related to Crowdswell Disorder. Now, we still don't fully understand it, but it's a very common syndrome. You're the 56th person I've diagnosed it to today—"

"I don't understand. What is it?"

A sigh. He's heard the question too many times.

"It means you suffer from thinking that every idea has been thought before."

I sat still, using the silence to absorb the words. I realized I *had* heard of it before. It was an illness that was talked about in the news of the human intranet. My coworkers all knew someone in their family who had it, and they all feared getting it.

"It's a complex syndrome. Even thought erasure therapy is ineffective because it keeps coming back. I'm going to prescribe to you our best solution to it for now. Sometimes it works wonders, sometimes it doesn't. It's called a vignette journal. A vignette is a brief written account that captures a specific moment in your life, with imagery and meaning, written by you. I want you to write these as often as you can. Simply describe your everyday life. Try to aim for five to ten a day, but ideally, the more the better; there is no limit. Once you have many in your journal, you'll have physical proof that your experiences are unique compared to others, and it will start to cure your syndrome. Give it a try."

"Thanks, doctor."

As I began to leave, he said, "Maxwell."

I turned.

"I know you're still recovering from that night when you woke up and remembered nothing. I've seen patients like you before: they can't find government records of themselves, they experience hallucinations, they're convinced they're just another copy in an echoing world—it's a dangerous combination. Right now, you don't have a tether. You need to find one as soon as possible, or you might lose the rest of yourself that you still have."

#

"Claudia Holly is in grade two," said Olivia, your foster care coordinator. "She's a very shy but good kid. A bright student. Very good at math."

"Hi," you said with a meek voice, your hands behind your back. "My name is Claudia."

#

When I told you I had seen much of the world, you became the incarnation of curiosity.

"What's the city really like?" you asked, on the drive home after I picked you up from Brightstep Fold. The place had been your world your whole life—you didn't know anything beyond its walls, did you?

"Let me think…"

When I describe the city to children, it's in a truthful manner. It's a land where no one knows how many people there are, no one knows how we got here, no one knows if there are other worlds, no one knows who's at the top and who's at the bottom, and no one knows what to do

next. One could spend a lifetime questioning up the ladder of politicians and corporate leaders in an attempt to discover the truth. And so, I always say: the city planet is timeless, the city planet is infinitely dense, the city planet is infinitely old, the city planet is infinitely divine. At the same time, it's infinitely beautiful.

Then I'm reminded of the absence of community, the fragmented families, the collapse of social cohesion. The siblings who grow up together but put space between them in different subdistricts for job security. The ties we are forced to make with strangers, and the overall plummeting numbers of children in our district. That's right. You're a rare sight.

"It's a place where you can ask anyone to be your friend," I said instead. "Can you be my friend?"

You laughed, but I didn't know if you believed me.

#

The sun is up, the world is breathing, the morning feels like a blank page itself. I'm holding the pen with equal parts hope and hesitation, and I have one more chance to make something meaningful out of the ordinary.

I clicked the pen to retract it and snapped the journal shut. I placed both inside my backpack and prepared for another commute to work.

At the train station, life and time seemed like a blur, moving along with the Crowd on a march until death. Light fought against the dark clouds to reach the glass skywalks and precipices of heights beyond numbers, which hung over steep drops into the branches and bridges connecting skyscrapers below in the city. Thunder boomed, rain fell, and water washed away the droplets of the previous shower on the surfaces of people's umbrellas.

I alone waded through the Crowd as if struggling to escape a pool of honey, clutching my belongings against frictions of skin and suits and pickpockets. Water washed the anti-slip yellow bumps on the metal platform of the station, designed meticulously for this repeated scenario day after day. Glass canopies shielded us from the torrent and allowed us a spectacular view when staring straight up—like being under a forest of redwood trees all converging to a single point straight above you, but the trunks were the paths of the droplets which flickered on the lines like the dashes of a road.

Intersecting paths caused bumps and *excuse me's,* wireless waves transmitted to phones powered conversations between people here and not here, and trains smoothly arrived and departed carrying millions to work on the dawn of a new but unoriginal day.

The digital clock in the corner of the station sounded, and the sight of the new numbers caused a rush—I collided with a woman, and we both apologized. A child was shoved into me, and I straightened him upright and said, "Careful out here, don't be trampled by the stampede." He nodded in a way that told me he was already an expert at surviving crowds like these.

Time passed, and the Crowd cleared up slightly. I saw a man in a long, dark raincoat and red tie walking ahead of me. A tiny notebook fell out of his coat pocket, but he kept walking.

I rushed to pick it up and called out to him before I lost him in the Crowd. The book was open when I picked it up.

"Excuse me! You dropped this."

7:12 am. Today's date is… does anyone know?

The sun is up, the world is breathing, the morning feels like a blank page itself. I'm holding the pen with equal parts hope and hesitation, and I have one more chance to make something meaningful out of the ordinary.

I stared at the words he wrote on today's page, baffled.

He turned around and ran up to me. “Oh, thank you! That’s the vignette journal my doctor prescribed to me. It’s for a special syndrome that he said I have.”

“Where did you get this?” I looked at him incredulously, pointing to the line he had written.

“I wrote that this morning. Just a little memento, as the doctor said to do.”

Although I had no right to, I flipped through the pages of his journal. Every few lines, a phrase or entire sentence would be the same as what I had written in my journal.

“I’m sorry, can I have it back now?”

I looked at him again. “Who *are* you?”

“My name is Rami Al-Ghareeb,” he said, as if we were businessmen.

“Oh.” I was expecting something more significant—the man held my own words after all. So, without thinking, I asked, “Is that supposed to mean something?”

He wasn’t pleased with the question. But then he laughed in a hearty way that made me feel like we were old friends.

“Well, not to *you,* I suppose. You’re a strange one, my friend. What’s your name?”

“Maxwell Ken.” I handed back his journal.

“Thank you for finding my journal interesting. I wouldn’t mind if you read it, but I have to pick up my daughter from her sleepover at her friend’s house.”

“You have a daughter?”

“Yes, but she’s adopted.”

Then he was gone. Lost in the planet-contiguous Crowd where every third millionth man was named Rami Al-Ghareeb.

#

Since the last Cultural Reemergence, it was almost impossible to find songs that didn’t contain gibberish lyrics and random noises to achieve originality. The principles of *crowdgaloria* didn’t permit voices in Geopolis to reuse ideas or tunes, and it was essentially an instant condemnation for zero profits. Wackiness supremely persisted, causing art to become incoherent. Those who followed Classicism were destined for failure, and the Crowd would ensure it by publicly denouncing them.

But as the moon of eras waxed and waned, the city planet undulated between modern crowdgaloria principles and Classicism. The rise of the Golden Age eras (of which there were dozens of them) proved that, with enough time, collective nostalgia would yearn for the media of eld. Back and forth we surged and retreated into times of deep hatred for all that had been done before, and all that was inarticulate and unconventional for the sake of remaining innovative.

I remembered that morning when I fried Summit Prime bacon from Feeder World #243 and eggs from Feeder World #139 for breakfast, and you—that pioneer of sound you were—hummed a tune as you coloured with crayons, one that sounded like it was from a Classicism era, judging by how well I could understand it:

“An ocean, endless blue
From infinite crowds, there is
Me. One fish, dreaming”

You told me it was a special song your mother used to sing to you when you were little, before she and your father died. It’s one of the only things about her that you remember.

“It’s beautiful,” I said. “Where did she hear it?”

You shook your head, then smiled teasingly.

"She made up the lyrics after reading a poem. Did you know she was a singer before she died? She always got inspiration for lyrics from poetry. This one was secret between us, and it was never released as a song. Now you know it, Mr. Ken. We are the only two in the world that know it."

I didn't want to tell you the likely truth. That from the principles of crowdgaloria, the lyrics weren't as unique as you thought. You were too young to understand how Geopolis worked.

Yet, something about the lyrics reached out to me, like a mother to a great-great-great-grandson. Something pure and heartfelt, an authentic source that told me I could be certain you were right, and we were two holders of a secret beyond any Geopolis principle, beyond all logic.

I learned they were from an incredibly old poem. Your mother must have read it as a haiku from the Japan District, considering the structure of the words, and at some time in the past, it must have been translated. I told you this, as well as how old haikus were, as a fun fact to impress you. But you only shook your head, dissatisfied.

"No! The poem is much, much older than that. My mom told me."

#

In the following months, Dr. Mei and I continued to build our information theory.

"Before the AAA hypergravitational stabilizers, the feeder world TITAN propulsion systems, and the elementary particle crackle-resistant engines, information transcending the limits of individual memory was the single most tremendous impact on civilization," said Dr. Mei. "We started with our ten fingers, then paper, then computers. We invented culture, writing, and history. So, it's imperative to start with why we're doing the research in the first place. Maybe you're right that doing an experiment with an—to put it bluntly—*unorganized* method of collecting results is pointless. I had hoped to embed knowledge in a secure chamber that was protected from the noise of the world by time, but I think we need to look deeper."

Outside our lab windows, we could see the city at night. It was a clear sky. From our vantage point on our skyscraper, across the Lake Ontario Subdistrict, we could see the Royal Botanical Sky Gardens of the Burlington sector.

"Take a walk with me," said Dr. Mei.

We boarded an ultralocal maglev rail from SuperUnion and passed by the Mississauga Nexus and Oakville Gate micro-hubs. We reached the Burlington Node in ten minutes.

From there, we took a maglev elevator and soared upwards to reach the Sky Gardens. The doors opened up to a magnificent atrium full of Old Earth flora. Magnolias and flowering cherries, redbuds and dogwoods, lilacs and peonies—I breathed it in and tried to imagine what living in Old Earth would have been like.

The atrium opened up to the hanging gardens section. This was the highlight. Many famous officials of the Canada District visited this place, a glorious floating walkway anchored to massive cantilevers and overgrown with plants, so that it almost seemed like a suspended jungle world between the earth and the sky. Hanging above the city below, the breath of the wild wind was howling, and the walkway's supports heaved with a deep groan. Benches for the brave faced outward on the edges, where users' feet would dangle above the vast extent of Geopolis's sprawl.

Get away from there.

It's okay. I won't fall. You can trust me, Mr. Ken.

Dr. Mei and I attached our metal safety belts. The whole section was surrounded by an anti-gravity system that propelled those who fell off back onto the walkway using magnetism. As long as we wore our belts, the hanging gardens were completely safe.

The skywalk shook as a storm began. The clear sky from earlier vanished, replaced by dark

grey clouds and the distant rumble of thunder. Lightning flashed scarily close by, but the same electromagnetic field that protected us from falling also caused them to bounce off. Geopolis's famous eternal rain returned, blurring the view of the incalculable twinkling city lights of the surface.

"I think humans have a specific role related to information," said Dr. Mei.

We were hanging on sky swings, our legs dangling in the air. We went here so many times to brainstorm that fear had become an afterthought.

"Historically, it's always been the case that civilizations aim to preserve knowledge. It's what gives them power."

"And now we're doing it too much," I said, thinking of the Dead Internet.

"Indeed. I've been thinking about how human information is transmitted. Raw meanings always stay the same, but languages change the way they're said. Consider the phrase, 'I eat at 11:30AM.' If you say the sentence in Chinese, the literal translation would be 'I noon eleven o'clock thirty minute have a meal.' Either way, the message gets across. This means language is just a medium we use to transmit ideas, giving us predictability. If the Old Earth philosophers were right, ideas are the highest form of reality, and we could use any medium to portray them. Even pure randomness, if we wanted, where the appearance of any structure would damage the message. Where the more predictable a pattern is, the less information it conveys."

From now on, when I say hippopotamus, it will mean I'm hungry.

Okay.

Hippopotamus.

Well, what do you want for dinner?

What do you mean? It means I love you.

You said it means you're hungry.

Well, I just changed it. You're supposed to know that, I thought we had a link!

"I think it's the key to solving crowdgaloria," said Dr. Mei. "We will never return to the days of scarce information. We must adapt."

Don't worry, I knew. I was just testing you. Looks like you failed.

Hey! That's so not fair.

"Something's bothering you," she noticed. "You've been off our work lately. I can tell."

At times, Dr. Mei was intimidating. She had a face that scared yet allured you at the same time. Her hair was always neatly wrapped in a bun with escaping side bangs, and her lab coat always smelled fresh and flowery like it had just been cleaned. Everyone at Arcalane thought she was a proper genius, and she was knowledgeable about a lot of things. I trusted her.

I nodded. I hesitated to find the right words.

"I feel like I'm always looking for someone. I don't know who it is, but it *feels* like someone I know, or someone I used to know. It's been happening for days now: I walk around the city trying to remember, trying to look for them. But at the same time, I don't know if they still care about me or even remember me at all. But I'm not worried. For some reason, I feel like our meeting again is inevitable."

I sighed. "I know it doesn't make sense. It might be a side effect of the Crowd, or extreme stress."

She nodded. I didn't know exactly what image she had in her head about it, but she seemed to know what I was trying to say. She always did.

"It's not the Crowd, Maxwell. I know what you're feeling."

"You do?"

She nodded. “That feeling in your heart: it’s called *yuanfen.* It’s the intuition that all coincidences are fated, all connections predestined. *Yuanfen* is the natural affinity that brings people together, fatalistic in that it suggests encounters are not fleeting to chance, but voluntaristic by implying our past choices shape these connections in the first place. It’s a cosmopolitan empathy with mankind.”

She pulled out her notebook and opened a page:

緣份

“This is how you write it. The radical in the first character means ‘silk,’ with the component attached to it meaning ‘connections.’ The second character is associated with ‘portion’ or ‘part.’ Combined, the word means every soul is always connected to one of two ends of a thread, no matter how many lives or places they wander. Strangers who become inseparable lovers or best friends after many chance encounters are said to have great *yuanfen*.”

As expected of Dr. Mei, she ended it in the most logical way possible:

“I think a few centuries ago they performed experiments to determine if it’s a type of *morphic resonance*, as if there were invisible fields of waves in biology—just like in physics—for a type of collective unconscious affected by all previous lives in nature. They taught rats how to complete a maze, and they’d repeat the experiment on the other side of the world and were shocked to learn the rats there had learned it faster. But all further experiments failed to produce any statistically meaningful results, and the field has been branded pseudoscience—the traditional way to defame a failed scientific theory. I’m not sure if you believe in anything past that, but I don’t.”

For a moment, her eyes looked lost as she recalled a memory.

“The truth is, I’ve worked on ideas like these before. I used to be obsessed with studying concepts that have no proof. The last time I did, I was ridiculed, and it almost cost me my career. Since then, I don’t believe in anything that doesn’t have proof I can see with my own eyes.”

In that moment, I understood why certainty was so rare—and so precious.

#

There was an umbrella that Brightstep Fold gave you. It was navy blue and had a goldfish pattern on it. By design, if you spun the umbrella, it looked like the goldfish were swimming. “Look, Mr. Ken!” you said, every time you did it to shake the water off at the front door, regrettably wetting my apartment each time. You liked to do that a lot.

From the indistinguishable fish on your umbrella, you told me you had a favourite. You liked to point at it and talk to it, and although I could not do it myself, you told me you could find the same one every time.

The umbrella is radially symmetrical. There are no words I can use to describe which one you picked, and often I doubted your ability to find the same fish repeatedly without fail, but you were certain you could find it every time. The fish were hopelessly identical to me. I tried my best.

“Every other fish is the same, I can’t tell the difference,” I said. “I don’t understand how you do it. Why did you pick that fish in particular, and how can you always find it?”

“Cause I like it!”

#

I was lost in a colourful stream, a digital world the Crowd had given up on long ago. The

Dead Internet was vast, but it held only floating whispers of human activity. Machines harped endlessly, powered by seemingly infinite energy from the HelioNet arrays, the aethercatcher wreaths, and the photonic mantles. This age was transcendent, and otherworldly sacred beasts painted flawless pictures, breathed life into lyrical conversations, and dreamed impressionistic summaries of mankind's information. They sputtered, reflected, and murmured morphemes into graphemes, then scattered their voices at unimaginable rates amongst the bit-speckled stars of their world like light circling the globe under sevenths of a second. As the city approached the limit of the number of people, the digerati built their digiarchs in this netspace, and beneath the mathematical constitution, they preached their inauthentic content. Yet, since the dawn of the city planet, all of life and cyberlife held no more audience.

It was another principle of crowdgaloria, and this was what we were dealing with. When I left this world after a long day of work, I faced the Crowd, and it was all the same to me.

Dr. Mei finalized her theory that humans were information conversion machines, their cosmic purpose to create information out of nothing and inhale high-entropic atoms and exhale the organization of them out. She said we should have known it from the start. We fought our whole lives to do it, and when we died, the most important thing we thought about was who would remember us.

I didn't want to believe Dr. Mei that lives were meaningless breaths born into the world only to fight for information survival. That we were soldiers in a war against a universal environment hostile to memory, our minds destined to gradually fade, intended to spend countless nights studying mathematical equations in dorm rooms and inherit textbook words of the past to build the future until the reset of the next generation.

But not everything was done. The next time we talked, she showed me the equations on the whiteboard she had been working on to solve the eternal protection of information from noise. She showed me how she developed a transform that could change a signal from the time domain to the *causality domain,* where each component reflected not when or how fast something occurred, but *how much it influenced other signals.* The problem was that her equations were missing variables—they theoretically worked if values were inserted, but she made them up for the sake of example and didn't know where they'd come from in the real world.

She still had one more goal, and she needed my help: to figure out the model that humans depended on to survive the sea of misinformation that we lived in.

#

The worst thing that ever happened was when I lost you in a mall.

In the eyes of an Old Earth citizen, the mall would seem endless. To take even ten steps in a direction required one to put their paranoia of the Crowd in a box, to discover its vibrantly lit stores and shiny marble floors with loud freedom. A philosopher of the second Cultural Reemergence once said, "Nothing worth it feels safe." We were trying to listen, you and I, and heeded the call to explore with our curiosities wide open.

The mall megalopolis was an urban colossus, half under the night rainy sky and half indoors with glass ceilings, both reminding you of the eternal rain in our district by design. Chains of stores built the hub of activity, the concrete roads glisteningly wet as people stressfully rushed in and out of sliding doors with their umbrellas. Lightning flashed behind bright billboards in various shapes and sizes of rectangles. Words in a dozen different languages exploded on them, along with beautiful faces that mesmerized masses, and chatter buzzed in the background. C-416's handed out baked croissants, sizzling mozzarella sliders, fresh starlyre fruits, and matcha pastry puffs.

One of them gave you a Yumdrop Swirl—the latest product from Candiverse Unlimited,

made from the saccharine sap of the trees of Feeder World #374. All the kids went crazy for it, and you became one of them when you begged for permission to eat it. I snatched it away from you. Your eyes were convincing enough, so I returned it, promising to double your serving of broccoli for tomorrow's dinner. As you licked it, your tongue turned blue.

We were in an open space outside the washroom hallway entrance, where I figured it would be fine to leave you temporarily.

"I have to use the washroom," I told you. "Wait here."

You nodded, lowering your head to avoid strangers as you licked the Swirl.

When I returned, the open space was quickly filled with people, and I spent a short while searching for you in the Crowd. I refused to panic because this was a scenario I never expected to be in, and because of that inexperience, it didn't feel real.

When the Crowd disappeared and I still couldn't find you, only then did I realize that I had lost you in the flood of the world. Ten minutes passed. I started to panic. I asked a mall cop if she had seen you.

"Have you lost your child?" she asked.

"Yes, I cannot find her. I told her to wait outside the washroom entrance over there."

The cop asked me to describe you. Then she radioed this description to her colleagues.

"She could not have gone far. We will find her, don't worry."

Memories had been returning to me. When my grandfather was on the brink of death, my family took a maglev ride to the Senescence Hub to visit him. He couldn't recognize any of our faces, and I had been too young to truly know him. Did this person still love me if they didn't know me? Did I have a duty to someone I didn't know?

Young me didn't think so. As nurses rushed in and out, as my family shed tears and discussed options, I was too busy on my NK Playslate to care. But my parents believed otherwise and fought hard to make him remember. They put faith in a force more powerful than memory and showed it by caring for him. I thought it was foolish at the time, but it did teach me that there were some things that didn't make sense to the universe but made sense to us.

What I mean to say is, without memory, you would not be lost.

Consequently, this meant the Crowd had no part in losing you. I was unable to rely on this Crowd of strangers to take care of you, for they had no memory of you. I alone held the memory necessary for your well-being, and it is this perceived responsibility within us that gives us our sense of duty.

#

The cop and I finally made progress when I called Olivia.

If anyone knew where you might have gone, it was her. The ringing of the call felt vulnerable. Finding you was dependent on this phone, which was dependent on whether she wasn't busy at this instant of time. In these few seconds, your fate could be decided by an invisible link across the streets of Geopolis connecting two devices.

In the seconds between each ring, I couldn't help but think: even in a city of a million billion people, even with all the technology we made to circumvent that, there was still no way to summon a person when it mattered most.

"Hello, Maxwell?" Olivia's voice broke through.

I explained everything as the officer listened quietly beside me.

"Oh no," she said, her voice tightening. "I think I may know where she might've gone. I gave her some money to buy you a thank-you gift for everything you've done for her. I told her to get help from you to pick it out. But knowing her, she would've tried to surprise you and gone on

her own. I warned her against it, but she didn't listen. You need to check the nearest toy store."

The cop contacted her colleague near the toy store, and soon after, we found her.

"I was so scared, Mr. Ken." You said this with shaky breaths, and I could tell you had been sobbing for an hour. "I'm so sorry! I was trying to buy you a gift, but then, but then, I couldn't find the way back to the washroom. I was so scared."

"I know. It's okay."

When life slows down, it reminds us again that the fear of the Crowd is inescapable. Later, I learned you were trying to get me a limited-edition stuffed pony. The fact that it was limited made it important to you by virtue of ephemeral novelty. I understood you best then, that what made things precious to you were local experiences lived only through you and the people around you. I was overwhelmed, overintellectualized, entangled by philosophy. You were innocently myopic. All else of the Crowd didn't matter to you, not in the way it did for those who've lived in Geopolis for over forty years.

I remember holding you until you calmed down. It's okay. I can make your world smaller.

#

The rain pitter-pattered on some days, but thump-thumped on others. Its incessant noise was something everyone in my district was used to. Wind challenged my balance on the metal catwalk I was on, which was attached to the side of a business complex, tightly weaving around the narrow valley of buildings with sides plastered with neon signs. The buildings around me were so tall that they blocked the night sky. When I looked over the few railings to the darkness below, I saw the faint lights of the lower levels of Geopolis, where the most isolated and lonely of society suffocated against the Crowd.

The following autumn, Brightstep Fold called me and gave the abrupt news that a family had chosen to adopt you. If you packed your things tonight, you could be ready to go by noon tomorrow.

I stood still at the doorway, awkward. From now on, someone else would pack your red schoolbag and teach you the secrets of camp games. Someone else would know the girl who made up dances to T-42 toaster sounds and named all the ceiling cracks in her room.

We were quiet.

"Do you have your chip?" I asked, because it was something to say.

You nodded. You tapped the spot behind your ear, where the small glint of your ID flickered once. You were slowly spinning your faded goldfish-patterned umbrella.

"Where is he?" I asked.

You stopped the spin and scanned the fish. You pointed to him. "Here."

That's my girl.

As I buttoned up your raincoat, you said, "Will I remember you?"

I blinked. The question was too sudden for the weight it carried.

"I don't know. Maybe not."

You nodded like that was acceptable.

"But I'll remember you," I added quickly. "Every day. Even when my brain gets old and the Crowd gets bigger, I'll still know there was a girl who spun umbrellas and sang million-year-old songs."

You smiled. You leaned forward and wrapped your arms around my neck.

I didn't know where I was going. I was wandering the catwalk paths of my neighbourhood, passing dirty vending machines, leaking pipes, and teenagers smoking Penrose-456. I felt tiny. I ducked under thick bundles of power lines and shielded my eyes from steamy holo-advertisements

of undressing people. *Money now! Makeup! Join newsletter! How to improve yourself!* A black and white cat jumped across a gap and its upper body caught the edge, scrambling up and narrowly escaping a fall into the city's abyss.

When you pulled away, you didn't cry. That part, I had done right. You weren't afraid of leaving.

"Time to go," you whispered, as if saying it quieter would make it less true.

The catwalks were metal lattices so the endless rain could fall through. The water formed small streams and dripped onto lower level after lower level, eventually reaching the mythical sewer canals no one had ever seen. The catwalk rattled under the murky waterfalls. Each of my steps clanged and rang out. I shivered.

Gamblers and drunks tested their luck beneath me. Socialites and stray dogs yawned for bedtime above me. The city was alive at all times and in all places. The dim glow of flickering neon lights diffused into the sky. I kept walking. Wire mesh fences, graffiti, security cameras, and staircases that plunged into darkness. The smell of ozone, grease, hot plastic, and petrichor. I reached an opening that led me to an elevated platform with a railing that overlooked a part of the city. I could tell I was on an Old Earth cliff, for the expanse of the view was amazing, and the drop down was equally terrifying. The wind here was more powerful, and as I breathed it in, thunder boomed somewhere.

"Claudia!"

We turned and saw Olivia outside, there to pick you up. She was holding her umbrella in the rain. She nodded at us.

You turned around. "Bye, Mr. Ken."

Then you disappeared into the flow of people, swallowed by the bodies more numberless than time and space, and bounded out the door into the watery typhoon. That's how I lost you.

I looked up and saw the droplets come one by one. I exhaled. I didn't know it yet, but tonight was the night, and a few hours would pass like eighty years.

That night in my bed, I fell asleep, and my Great Dream began.

Lu Xianzhi

Oil lamps and their soft glow in the dim interior. A faint aroma of steamed dumplings. A mat of woven straw, walls of sun-dried bricks and bamboo, and the anxious, shuffling bodies of my extended family members. My mother's face.

These were the first memories I knew.

"You are beautiful," said my mother, touching my nose.

"He will bring honour and strength to our family." My father's voice. He sat beside my mother and shared the cradling of my new presence. "We will name him Xianzhi."

For many years, I watched the world go by as the village and elders watched my life mature, each day more easily recalled than the last. I would learn how to be an honest, hardworking farmer. In my days that began at dawn, I learned how to satisfy the chickens' clucks, how to pick the most aromatic herbs from the garden, and how to harness the oxen with a yoke. The village elders enriched my knowledge with their years of experience. They showed me how to read and write, how to tell the stars apart in the sky, where we lived and how we got here.

I grew up curious and wild. I kicked feather-stuffed leather balls with other kids on damp dirt roads. I climbed shingled rooftops to capture the wind with my kite. I chased chickens around streets and markets just because I could.

My parents told me the mountains around our village were sacred because gods and spirits lived there. The greatest of them all was the Cosmic Dragon King, at the top of the tallest mountain. Legend says that one day, as he rested on his peak on the night of a winter's eve, his supreme vision witnessed a blinking light on a faraway land on the other side of the world. It shone across the ocean brighter than the brightest stars. It switched states rapidly and randomly but with purpose, as if a code by intelligent design. Even using all the wisdom in the world, the Cosmic Dragon King couldn't decipher its mysterious pattern. But the contrast of light and dark taught him about the tiniest minimum of communication, about the interconnectedness of opposites, and thus, the idea of balance was revealed. That was how Yin and Yang were born. Several centuries later, the great Laozi would include it in his book of Daoism.

"You must start studying for the civil service exam," my father told me. "When you are older, you will have the chance to take it and escape for a better life."

I was born in a golden age, he told me. A time of meritocracy, cut taxes, freed slaves, and the rise of the common people. If I worked hard enough, I could obtain a position in the government. This was a prosperous time for the Han Dynasty.

There was no better time to follow the teachings of the wise sage Confucius and work together to become one whole. Each man, woman, and child had a role in our society, and keeping this harmony was of utmost importance if we wanted our empire to be strong.

When I grew older, the matchmaker of our village found me a wife. It was a drop of control in a bucket of disorder. My parents didn't like taking a chance with fate.

"How much did they really control?" my new wife said on the birth of our fifth child. We named her Haiyang. Between our glances, there lingered so much left unsaid, and she smiled like a *huli jing*. The inevitability of our love was unplanned, yet conspicuous as fireflies at midnight. Little Yangyang yawned as I tickled her cheek. A new force was born into the world, and I felt it. That's you.

Your grandparents helped raise you while I studied for the civil service exam. Your grandfather had a rare connection to someone in the capital to help me. Master Geng was a renowned teacher in the Taixue. One day, he was visiting our village with a broken wheel on his carriage. Your grandfather used his knowledge of tools to fix it, earning Geng's gratitude—and a lasting bond between them. As a favour to my father, this spring, I would enrol as his student in the Imperial Academy.

If you saw my face on the first day, you would have laughed. I was terrified.

"Starting today, you are Scholar Lu," said Master Geng. His voice was like a commander's.

I gave him a deep bow. Then the next few words changed my life forever.

"Unlike other students, you will not be here to study for the civil service exam."

I looked up, puzzled.

"I don't need a wise or arrogant young man. Honestly, all they're good for is trouble. Your father said you were a curious kid growing up. That's all I need. You will be helping me with a secret mission directly from the emperor himself. We must figure out how to make the emperor's poetry last forever."

The news was exciting—but also daunting. It would only be later in our days of research that I would truly understand the impossibility of such a task.

Master Geng told me that a painting's information never changed because human eyes didn't change. Interpretations did. But poetry was different—it was built on language, and for language, both the way words were written *and* interpretations could change.

And so it began: our mission to eliminate the possibility of these two.

#

Before I knew it, you had grown up. One moment, I was kneeling beside your crib, whispering lullabies into the soft wisps of your hair, watching your chest rise and fall like the gentle swell of a tide.

Then the years overlapped like the sands of the Gobi Desert. Your first words, your first scraped knee, the way you used to run to me when thunder shook the windows. I blinked, and suddenly your voice was steady, your walk was confident, and your thoughts were your own.

I wanted everything in our house to be tidy. I wanted the stone floors swept, the brushes arranged, and the clay pots in line. You were always my opposite, throwing leaves into the air from outside, leaving smudges of dirt where I had swept, and giggling at the delicate porcelain vessels teetering on the edge of tables.

Your mother was furious. “Listen to me and your father!”

I didn’t get mad at you. “Come,” I said softly, holding a small wooden box carved with intricate patterns of dragons and clouds. “I have something for you.”

You plopped down, and your mother exhaled at your whirlwind’s end.

Inside, nestled in a sheet of silk, was a small bundle of bamboo strips. You tilted your head, and I smiled. I took two of them and started weaving. You were entranced. When I finished, a small bird was in your hands.

“Try making something with these,” I said.

As you grew up, you grew obsessed with this ancient craft. You made a variety of animals. Tigers, water buffaloes, pandas, and fish. Each time, I was delighted.

“Another bird?” I said, when you were working on your tenth one.

After that, you started making different things. Mountains, butterflies, dancers, lanterns, toys. With each new creation, I celebrated with you, and fuelled by my pride, you made more. They would appear next to me when I woke up every morning. Always something different.

#

When the great Lord Cai had perfected the crafting of his new invention, the dynasty was reinvented anew. Bamboo, hemp waste, old rags, fishnets, and tree barks—nothing went to waste with his new technique. Now we were efficient in literature, efficient at thoughts being recorded at a moment’s notice and to the end of time. One step closer to the infallible preservation of wisdom.

We called it paper, and we used it to make scrolls. Within a few years, they became the dominant format for poetry, proverbs, and administrative documents. It was as if Heaven had willed it so that our empire would flourish under the recorded words of sages long, long past.

At first, Master Geng and I were overjoyed, thinking it would help us with our mission for the emperor. But there was a flaw. The day we learned we could still rip them, tear them, smudge them, and even burn them was one of our saddest days. In one instant, one could create order from nothing by jotting down words from philosophy, philosophy from thoughts—but just as fast could one tear the paper and release the precious information back into the sea of chaos. The revelation was a blow to our work.

We sought new avenues other than the physical realm. One day, when we were talking about the ideas of the great sages, Master Geng asked, “Do you believe human society is the result of individual human actions with their own intentions reaching an equilibrium, or the execution of a grand human design?”

I understood what Master Geng was implying. Confucius was a proponent of the latter, believing that only by virtue could humans build a truly prosperous society. He dedicated his life

to spring order from chaos. But Master Zhuang disagreed with Confucius and believed the opposite. He believed good order resulted spontaneously when things were let alone.

"What do you believe, Master Geng?" I asked.

He laughed. "How privileged it would be to disagree with the wisest among us! They are both right, Scholar Lu. Do you understand what it is that we must do? To make a poem survive countless ages against everything, we must make noise the carrier of our information. This means we must believe in the spontaneous order Master Zhuang proposed, but also hope for Confucius's structured world in which chaos is specifically implemented by design."

"But how do we find meaning in noise?"

He paused to think. "We don't, at least not directly. Meaning must emerge. Like stars in the sky—they are not put there for us to read, but we read them anyway. We trace constellations. We name them. What we call *information* is merely the shapes we notice in the flickering. We must design a system in which meaning becomes inevitable, where pattern cannot help but be seen. Silence must sing."

#

It was a cold day in Zhengyue, the First Month of the Taichu calendar. The courtyard was peaceful and silent, and you were reading your poetry.

"I want to know the very first idea," you said. "Even this Classic of Poetry, assembled by the great Confucius, is a collection of older works he put together. I must find the original people who wrote these poems, Father."

To help you, I thought of an idea.

"The Cosmic Dragon King on the mountain may know," I said. "Will you go?"

"It's an honourable idea. I've heard many pilgrims say the path is treacherous."

"So I've heard. Only for foolish, restless daughters."

You laughed. "Help me, Father. When I read these classics, I think the limit of wisdom has been reached. Every thought has been thought, every proverb has been said. Every tactic for warfare has been attempted, and every combination of notes on a guzheng has been played. Like a cat that pounces on its prey like its many ancestors before it, so too have we reached the pinnacle of wisdom, and we are left ill-fated at the end of it. Our wisest sage can do nothing but preach the lessons of the sages that were ancient in his own time. We repeat knowledge like the cycle of the sun and moon in the sky, when we should be creating new knowledge built on old like the sprouting branches of a willow tree."

Then you started singing. "*Look—at—us! In an infinite empire, two people dreaming…*"

It was there that I learned about your obsession with originality, the one that you so aligned with your perceived sense of purpose. This quest was yours to achieve from the very start. You believed stagnation held our dynasty back, that the only path forward was the conception of truly unique thoughts.

#

When he wasn't teaching, Master Geng spent most of his time cultivating himself. He brewed tea and sat next to the fishpond on the eastern side of the courtyard. Other students passed and watched him read ancient Daoist texts by the glimmer of the orange carp.

On a day that called forth the breeze of spring, he told me he had been "liberated by knowledge."

"I had been thinking about the relationship between order and chaos," he said. "What do the words even mean? Are they opposites of one and the same, as Laozi proposed all life is? Or were they created by human definitions to explain something we don't understand? Can we convert

something from one to another? Then I came across the passage from Master Zhuang that revealed to me the truth."

He read aloud:

> "*Once upon a time, I dreamt I was a butterfly, fluttering hither and thither, to all intents and purposes a butterfly. I was conscious only of my happiness as a butterfly, unaware that I was myself. Soon I awaked, and there I was, veritably myself again. Now I do not know whether I was then a man dreaming I was a butterfly, or whether I am now a butterfly, dreaming I am a man."*

"Don't you see, Scholar Lu? Order is an illusion. Reality itself is relative. How do you know you are Scholar Lu now? Will you be Scholar Lu tomorrow, when you wake? Is all but nought a dream? With this wisdom, we can apply it to our studies about poetry."

I was awed by his awakening and bowed my head slightly. "Teach me, Master."

"Very well."

He unfurled a scroll on the table and gripped his brush—strands of animal hair on a bamboo handle—and wrote the character for *dao*.

"Stuck in the prison of our minds, all we can know are the strokes of this character. But The Way is all-encompassing—to understand its true meaning, it cannot be simplified into just a single character. We only do so because that is how we interpret it, to make it easier for us to communicate it to each other. But if we were to find it everywhere, then it doesn't matter what form we choose to convey this information."

Then he drew lines starting at the ends of the strokes of the character. He snaked trails like the backs of dragons, curved, spiralled, and made diagonals all over the paper. The slithering ink sprouted from the central character all over the scroll like the growing vines of a garden. They wrapped around empty space and curled around air. He pushed strokes to the moon, the stars, and the sun. He guided ink like rivers and valleys to the ocean of discord. Soon, the character was lost in the new strokes, and the *information* was absent from view, but its lines connected seamlessly to the new picture. Although it was unintelligible against the noise, clarity remained.

Incredibly, I could still read it.

"The act of communication is the formation of order against disorder," he said. "To create meaning out of noise. But that is because that is the way we defined it from the start. If we could start a new definition for language, if we could hypothetically figure out a way to invert our traditional channels for communication, if chaotic noise became information and order became distortion, then we could generate meaning *from* noise, and the randomness of the world would become the source of our information itself. In this way, we could forever depend on this randomness to be the carriers of our poem's meanings, and they will be interpreted correctly for eternity."

The task was nearly impossible. But we worked hard day and night to find a way. We cut shoots of bamboo and asked others who had cut what to see if they could know without us telling them. We listened to the din of crowds and tried to find meaning in the collective noise instead of the meaning of the words of any individual person. We meditated to encode our thoughts in the wind, to experiment if future generations could decode the breeze to hear the sounds of our ideas.

Months passed, and as expected, nothing worked.

"We need to start small," I said. "You said nature does not care for our binaries. The great

Laozi said chaos and order are not enemies, and they even exist within each other. If they do, the fundamental properties about them are not the individual characteristics humans have assigned to them, but their *relationship* to each other."

I waited. Master Geng nodded approvingly. "Go on."

"To make our job simple, I wondered, what is the smallest unit of information? The great Master Zhuang once pointed at a tree growing from the side of a cliff and asked his student, 'Is it alive or dead?' The student could only answer yes or no. It occurred to me that these were the smallest pieces of any concept. You can describe any message in the world with a series of yes or no questions. Is it alive or dead? Is it an animal or not an animal? Is it a plant or not a plant? Is it a tree? *Yin, yang, yin, yang.* We could also use the last character to be affirmative, like true or false. By this system, that sequence means *tree.* If the world breathes in dualities, then it also speaks in them."

Master Geng nodded again. "You're brilliant, Scholar Lu! But there's still one problem. The system of questions needs to be invented so that each sequence will always mean the same thing, and that system must transcend time and space along with our message. And so we are back at the start, and order must still spring from chaos."

"Perhaps the universe already has its own system?" I wondered. "And we don't need to design our own?"

"Yes, you're right. Fortunately, I may have the answer. Last night, I was studying the same thing."

Master Geng spread a scroll on a desk. Using his brush, he created a table on the scroll. On the top row and the leftmost column, he inserted sequences of three lines, either broken or unbroken. On the rest of the table, he worked on filling in the combinations of the lines, then underneath, the number each represented.

"The old sages believed that in the cycle of change—what we call the *I Ching*—each line of a hexagram was either whole or broken. Yin or yang. Passive or active. Each hexagram held meaning not through individual lines, but through the *combination* of them. Do you see?"

My brow furrowed as I studied his table. "Like a message. A system of six lines that can express thought."

"Precisely," said Master Geng. "The Scripture of Changes consists of 64 hexagrams. But what's important is that the sages weren't using the hexagrams to describe their own messages—they were using them to describe the cosmos. They were intended to illustrate the nature of reality as being composed of mutually opposing forces reinforcing one another. One hexagram would mean 'fire,' another would mean 'earth.' Each line has two possible states, which allow for a total of two times itself three times, or eight trigrams. But with longer extensions of these characters, we could increase the possible binary values and write anything we want. We wanted a way to encode messages—even the smallest units of information—into the universe to make our poetry eternal, into the unpredictability of the noise of everything. This might be it. The Way reveals itself… one bit at a time."

His eyes turned wide, contrasting with his long beard. "It all makes sense now. Master Zhuang was right, but also wrong at the same time. He understood that spontaneous order was the natural way of the universe. But that was because what he perceived as order was actually chaos. The truth is more complex. Both are needed, and both are interchangeable."

After our breakthrough on inverting the traditional system of communication, Master Geng and I hosted a celebratory feast in the courtyard and invited other scholars. In the following months, we worked tirelessly to create a method that could achieve the encoding part.

But there was still a final problem. We understood now that noise and order were interchangeable, but Master Geng brought up a fair new point: if that was true, and there were no objective truths to anything, how had humans survived so long until now? If words could mean anything, if promises could be lies and lies could be promises—there had to be an underlying part of it all that we were missing. Or else civilization would never rise from the ground up.

Master Geng was convinced Confucius knew something about it. But Confucius mostly worked on ethics and running society. It was impossible to connect his teachings to our work.

I debated with my teacher that not every sage had to have had a great idea related to what we were doing, but Master Geng had a deep respect for Confucius, the greatest sage of them all, and believed with great faith that he was much wiser than us. The only way to find out was to study his texts.

#

You were holding your thousandth paper crane. This was your chance for a wish. You waited a long time for this.

You told me, "Focus on my world, and watch the lone experience transform into the divine." Then you threw the paper bird into the air, and it flapped its wings. It circled us, defecating balls of paper feces that unfolded into more birds of a vibrant array of colours. Half went clockwise, half went counterclockwise. Underneath our feet, a giant lotus flower bloomed, engulfing the air and the earth and shifting the ground like the mouth of a behemoth, its petals rupturing like the waves of sound, spiralling and spinning and unweaving the entire spectrum of light. Paper scarlet skimmers and yellow swallowtails danced and sang phrases that touched on the core of their individual experiences, and when I heard their words, I saw what they saw, heard what they heard, tasted what they tasted.

"I went to the Cosmic Dragon King," you said, your hair a streak in the wind. "Even with his infinite wisdom at the top of his mountain, he didn't know the answer. He could not find the original source of all stories in the world. He could not find the source of the Classic of Poetry, the Book of Songs. So, as you know, he taught me how to fold these birds using Lord Cai's paper for a wish instead. But if even the Cosmic Dragon King does not know, I did not think using the wish on it was worth it. We will be forever disconnected from true originality."

"Then what did you wish for?" I asked you.

You smiled. "Look around us, father! I wished for a sight to remember, that only the two of us in the world will know."

#

"The empire has too many people, and the emperor has lost sight of humanity. He no longer sees the common folk. He is too detached, losing the Mandate. Rebellions will rise, floods and droughts will come, and times will get dangerous."

My father had returned from his trip to the base of the Cosmic Dragon King's mountain. Sometimes, although rarely, mystics who followed the Cosmic Dragon King would be there, practicing divination rituals to predict the future. Those were their exact words, my father said, after he relayed the message to the village.

This was heavy news to you. You told me you couldn't sleep at night, tossing and turning, sweating through all your clothes. "Just like I said, Father," you began, "we live in an eternal cycle, all because we can only repeat ideas. Why does our civilization never learn? I want to know how to break free. Then, I want to teach everyone how to break free."

"Stay indoors," I warned you. "You have to put your quest on hold. At least until we get more information about the situation in the capital."

The Silk Road was beginning to flourish at this time. Monks from distant lands were travelling in caravans, bringing new writings on dried palm leaves. I should have known such an event would ignite your curiosity—it was the perfect opportunity to find foreign ideas to save our empire.

One night, you couldn't take it anymore. The evening was warm and humid. You gave up on sleeping, grabbed my dao sword, pulled my horse out of our stable and rode off into the night. My sweet Yangyang journeyed by herself into the unknown, ignorant of the dangers beyond our dynasty's borders. You whispered that you would come back, but as Master Geng and I found out, promises could be lies in this world.

I learned the truth only much later. Something terrible had happened to you. You had been taken—ambushed by bandits along the Silk Road. They planned to sell you into slavery.

"She left because of you," said your mother. "You don't understand her, do you? Her quest to save the dynasty is a facade. When she was growing up, she always wanted to surprise you with the newest bamboo creation. Over time, her creations dulled on you, and you weren't as happy as before. She realized she needed to look further, for something new. She just wants you to be proud of her again. That's all she's ever wanted."

I've been on a quest for many years to find you now.

#

The Taklamakan Desert stretched wide, the dunes shifting and slithering. I covered my mouth with my silk scarf and pushed against the sandy wind. The cave was up ahead.

I believed I was close to finding you. After years of searching, all my efforts, and all the information I could gather about your whereabouts, it had led me to this. A cave where bandits kept and auctioned slaves to anonymous buyers.

The jail had many captive slaves, all of them young girls. An unbelievable, deplorable number of them. Each one was held prisoner under a dungeon designed to isolate them, to cast them away in dark, hidden chambers, so each could be forgotten by the world.

"I am looking for my daughter," I told them desperately. They pleaded with their eyes for me to save them. Did they not understand? They were strangers to me. "Please, I am just looking for my daughter. Her name is Haiyang. Do you know where she is?"

They were all like you. Their build, their size, even some of their faces. They blended with one another, all with pleading eyes. I was tasked with an impossible feat. I must find my daughter in this crowd of girls I didn't know.

Along the dark corridor, the lines of captive girls stretched with no end. There were features I could recall to find you. I could remember you by the way you threw back your hair, or by the sound of your laugh. I could identify you easily if I could ask these girls how she used to count to ten, or if I could find the birthmark on the back of your left hand. Memory was on my side, but in this prison, I did not have the immortality of the Jade Emperor to ask each one. Saving them was another problem altogether—one could not mend all the injured spotted doves in the world.

Then, a thought unfolded in my mind like a bloom—during the days Master Geng and I tested our ideas with the villagers, if they didn't know the answer to a question, we discovered that the first thing they did was ask someone else. Sometimes, they would chain this action indefinitely until they found someone who knew the answer. I understood then that when knowledge appeared in one person's world, it was because of other people who had found it already, built on trust. Master Geng was right about Confucius—social harmony was the answer. This was how we survived.

But time was running out before the bandits would find me, and I had to escape. If only I

knew who these girls were, and they knew me. But this barbaric world I had entered didn't allow for such connections—it was true nature didn't care about order, but humans did.

And so you remained lost, and I couldn't find you there. Their souls continued to plead for salvation as I left, with nothing I could offer the strangers.

#

I was dying. My deathbed was surrounded by my grandchildren, who had gathered to see me, and they remained by my side, quiet and respectful. Their parents had already begun the rituals for my death, and the smell of incense smothered the room. I couldn't stop coughing.

"What do you want us to do, as your final wish?" asked the oldest one. The little ones waited for my answer.

"Remember to study that poem I showed you," I said. "Pass it on to your children and never stop."

#

New lands await our discovery.

Consider the emergence of the Silk Road. Consider our old, collective view of the lands outside the borders of our empire. What was once merely a land of harsh desert, snowy mountains, and savage barbarians to us has now revealed great civilizations beyond the Han Dynasty. Perhaps it's optimistic, but I foresee a bold future where our two civilizations will expand along the path of this road, and we will merge to become an even greater power with a border encompassing all of Asia. Then, we will become one, and people will travel east and west and mix and trade, fuelled by our common camaraderie. Our numbers, at 59 million, will double. When other dynasties around the world see us flourish, they will join too, and our numbers will triple. Who is to say there is an end?

I once thought we were like wind-blown leaves, carried by currents of air from one destination to the next, leaving minimal impact on the places we go. I was wrong. The truth is, we are threads in an ever-woven fabric, infallibly interconnected. We may stretch the borders of our panorama without end, but we will forever be linked over and under each other, and any choice we make, any person we meet, will leave an imprint on other people's threads, and it will forever impact the greater picture. The story of us shows each individual contributing to our grand tapestry, each weaving their threads around others. This will be the most beautiful tapestry of all time.

When these threads are infinite, it means our stories have no ending.

Dear Haiyang, the Buddhist monk I encountered during my travels on the Silk Road promised me that one day you would return to this world. Now I believe I must write a poem, outlining the ideas you are destined to know. It will be my final message to you from this life. I will articulate these ideas in the form of inscribed words, and they will be passed on to my children, who will pass them on to their children. In this way, even against the ebb and flow of time, against the rise and fall of infinite dynasties, against the unjust will of life, these words will reach you.

Without a doubt, each generation will express the words differently. As such is the way of the world, a word will change here and there, a family member will hear it incorrectly, or the memory of a child hearing it will not be trusted. Do not worry, Master Geng has taught me well. I will design it with this in mind, and I alone will bear the task to weave the idea simple and pure, so that with each iteration, all the members of our family inadvertently help complete it, and our collective craftsmanship will make it an ardent example of true social harmony.

As long as the original meaning is not lost, no number of reincarnations will affect the heart of this poem. And so, my dear daughter, I admit that through the marvel of my boundless expectation, patience escapes me. I will die unable to wait, until benevolence and righteousness

are compelled by my longing's existence. My dear daughter, please wait for my arrival. As my death approaches, I humbly await the day that my words, through them an extension of me, will return to you.

Maxwell Ken

The train to work was the same as usual. The same gust of wind and musty smell when the doors slid open. The same shuffle of feet, the same blurred advertisements on the walls of the station, promising lives no one had reason to live. I stood like always, part of the Crowd, holding the railing with one hand and my thoughts with the other, watching the skyscrapers stream by, surrounded by huge, suffocating waves of pedestrians.

Dr. Mei and I continued searching for the source of her variables in her equations. Then the years folded into each other like paper, creased and tucked until I couldn't tell one from the next. Birthdays passed unnoticed, colleagues retired, and the building changed names. Projects became obsolete, and executives gave orders just to keep people happy. We still worked, hoping our labour could keep the world from forgetting us. I took pill after pill, treatment after treatment, all so I could keep helping Dr. Mei. I didn't know what else I'd do. One day, I looked in the mirror and I saw the wrinkles of a 108-year-old man.

Dr. Mei died a month ago. The last connection I had to who I used to be was gone.

Find her, she said. *Prove me wrong. Prove something can be true without me seeing it for myself.*

It was raining softly when I ducked into the sushi bar near the station. There were no empty seats, and each one had five others waiting in line. Like many others, I tried pushing past them to order something quickly and then leave, but after trying for a bit, I gave up. I collapsed onto the ground, my back against a wall, exhausted.

"By the look of your clothes, you work at Arcalane. So you shouldn't be on the ground like that."

I looked up to see the shrivelled man standing beside me. A bottle of Indigo Spirit was in his hands. Completely banned in most districts.

"You don't look like you belong in this district," I said.

He shrugged. "I had to find a place to think. Believe it or not, this was the best I could find." He slumped down next to me. "I don't trust anyone in this city, but you look fine. Don't tell me your name, or you'll ruin it."

From where we sat, the world seemed too large. Elevated walkways glowed like arteries of a living city, pumping endless foot traffic from giants as tall as the towers above. Hurried feet from the giants splashed puddles of clear water, murmuring voices chimed like lullabies, and the beating rain was the pulse, always there, always on time.

"Too many crowds, huh?" said the man.

"Just another Tuesday."

"Yeah."

I breathed along with the station. Fractured under wet sheen and buried under people, I tried to think my own thoughts. *No, I told you. Wait for me at the transfer gate. Unit 27A reporting a lost commuter pass again. Mom, I can't find my tablet! Departure to Algeria District delayed. Again. Next maglev in 2.5 minutes. Please stand clear. Zone 11 housing prices are up 18%—can you believe that? All this tech and still no way to find a quiet moment. Hey, hold the elevator, please.*

"I can't do this anymore," I said, clutching my head. "A hundred years of this, and I've forgotten what thoughts sound like. How do you still take it?"

The man shrugged and shook his bottle of Indigo Spirit. "This helps."

He exhaled. Then he started to sing: "*An ocean, endless blue! From infinite crowds, there is me. One fish, dreaming.*"

Hey, Mr. Ken. Hippopotamus.

I stared at him. "Where did you hear that song?"

#

That day, when the man sang that song, he told me about the librarian from whom he first heard it. When I went to the library, after a line of nearly twenty-six people, I reached the librarian, who told me she heard it from her friend who worked at a cafe. She gave me the address. When I took a maglev train to the district with the café, after a line of ninety people, I gained an opening to talk to the barista, who told me she heard the song from the café's music, which was a playlist created by the manager. She led me to the back of the shop, where I found the manager, who said he found the song from a small corner of the internet. It was sung by a cover artist. He told me he would find the song on his phone.

"It's been deleted," he said.

"What?"

"I don't know. There's an error message on the spot where the song used to be in my playlist." He showed me his phone to prove he wasn't lying. "I'm sorry. I don't know why. Maybe the creator decided to take it down, or some bot police system made a mistake. If it helps, I can tell you what I remember about the song."

He gave me the artist's name: Anna Mizuno. He also gave the title of the song and any other details he knew, and I wrote everything on a piece of paper. I could have saved the details on my phone, but after witnessing a disruption to my link to her a moment ago, I held an irrational distrust for it to reliably preserve this piece of crucial information.

To my surprise, everyone was highly cooperative, even those in unexpected places. I skipped work numerous times, and although my manager would be the first to notice, I took the risk. But even my manager wished me luck on my pursuit, after he contacted me about my absence and I told him the truth. It must have been true that Arcalane had too many employees to think about individually, that I was a statistic on their balance sheets, that I must be easily replaceable. My manager must have recognized the large effort it would take to report me to Arcalane's higher-ups, and the likelihood it would be unrecognized.

Or it meant he genuinely wanted to help.

"Careful, Maxwell," he said. "You know what happened to the Old Internet. That's why most of us left those spaces long ago. Even when you do find real profiles of this Anna Mizuno, there will be millions of them. Are you ready to spend time filtering through all that?"

"I have no choice," I told him.

"Make sure you use the best keywords."

He was right, the longest part was the search for the singer's profile. My old fingers glided across the keys of my keyboard, a fraction of the speed I used to be capable of. My failing eyes blurred the words on my screen. The lyrics of the song were unhelpful, and the singer's name even less so. Days passed with no progress.

Just as I was ready to give up, I received a call from a stranger.

#

"*Yes, I'm Anna Mizuno. Yes, I did sing that song, a very long time ago. Someone sold the*

lyrics to me. I think I can find out where she is for you.

Also, sorry for asking, but who is this?"

#

"She's been looking a long time for you," she said.

Before me was a wrinkled woman with glasses, seventy-two years old. She told me she was your adoptive sister. Her English was good, but from her accent, I could tell it wasn't her first language.

"She said these lyrics were special to her, and only I was trusted to turn them into a song. We grew up and went to different subdistricts. Before we parted ways, she told me if by some miracle I managed to run into you, I should give you this."

She gave me a piece of paper with an internet link. An internet link that could have been saved on a computer, but was now reduced to fading, smudging ink on a musty sheet of paper. There was nothing else but nature's erratic will separating our bridge and the void.

I laughed. When faced with the task of preserving vital information, you gambled on the physical world over the digital world. You were my daughter, after all.

#

The link led me to a blog.

The post on the Old Internet was from fifty years ago, from a woman named Claudia Suzuki. I put on my glasses and squinted at the words on the computer:

Whoever is listening,

I know it's a slim chance, but on that slim chance, I'm asking all of you, the followers of my blog, to help me with this task.

I once knew a man in my childhood. His name was Maxwell Ken, and I called him Mr. Ken. He was my foster father. The truth is, I don't remember much about him because I was only seven years old. Memory is so temporary in a world where we want everything permanent that we often struggle to recall the most important moments of our lives. But though details are always lost to time, what always remains are emotions. What I do remember is that he was the kindest and funniest man I had ever known.

I never told him why I'm an orphan. My parents died during the Gang World Wars of the previous century. The Alberta Subdistrict's Black Helix underworld leaders failed to complete their end of a bargain with the Michigan Subdistrict's House Umbriel, who had been smuggling Lucent-9 from the Fujian Subdistrict's Silk Coalition for years without compensation. The two factions waged a deadly battle on the streets. My parents were caught in the crossfire when I was three. Suddenly, I had nothing, and I became unfortunate in the world of memory. No one knew me. I drifted from one place to the next, eventually ending up at Brightstep.

Then one man took a gamble on me. He said, 'Okay, we might not know each other, we might not be real family, but starting now, pretend we are.' Nothing in his world of memory spurred him to do such an action. It was impulsive, instantaneous, fleeting. Irrational.

When I look back, I see our happy memories from the eyes of a content woman in the future. But what bothers me is that, from that rash decision of Mr. Ken to choose me, none of this was guaranteed. In a world where the originality of information no longer exists, Mr. Ken taught me we can still rely on the novel consequences of our free will. Like what he taught me, impulsive decisions in life are the only way to create meaning out of the noise in the universe—is this not the one true goal of every human being?

Today, I've dedicated my life to one of Geopolis's biggest problems: the Originality Paradox. I've spent years searching for the first ones who created the first meanings in the noise. I've studied era after era, discussed with experts, and hosted presentations at universities and research centres, all in an effort to find the first ideas by the first people of Earth's history. The time before we became the timeless Geopolis.

I was obsessed with it, consumed by it, torn by it. Two years ago, I discussed with another field expert the idea of collective originality versus individual originality. For most of my career, I had been so focused on the former, about the ideas that everyone already knew, that I began to realize there was a place with experiences that no one in the Crowd of a million billion could reach. So I spent days exploring my memory, and that was when I remembered Mr. Ken.

Mr. Ken wasn't just my best friend, father, or teacher. He was just someone else*. And all that we had been through was irreplicable. So, when I learned that a family had chosen to adopt me in the Japan District permanently, my heart broke at the insignificance of all our memories. I knew it was likely that I would never see Mr. Ken again.*

I haven't talked to that man in a long time.

But I didn't believe I would never see him again. The world is big, yes, but we have the internet. At least, that is what my naive young mind thought. I never completed my quest because the man moved out of his old apartment. The number we used to call him no longer worked. Social media was hopeless as there were millions of Maxwell Ken profiles, more than enough for a lifetime of checking, and because of how large, chaotic, and overwhelming Geopolis is with its million billion inhabitants, finding an old childhood friend was impossible. It was like releasing your pet fish into the ocean, then trying to find it years later.

I have been on a personal quest to find this man for decades. It is a quest I tell no one about, and it plays in the background of my life. I thought all was lost until I created this blog. Suddenly, countless people were on my side on various things and opinions, even if vaguely. Now I have a tool to really help my cause, and it requires the help of all of you. If there is anything you know about this story, this man, his name, the location of his apartment—even the ice cream shop we went to!—please help me and let me know.

We live in a time with access to infinite information, but we know so little about each other. I know most of you only through digital words, yet in a way, I feel connected. You will know more about me and my story if you read this, and we will still be strangers by knowledge, but no longer strangers by heart.

I don't know why, but I am certain I will eventually see Mr. Ken one day, even amongst the bustling streets of Geopolis, where every individual in the crowded city squares is trying to make their own life. I don't see strangers. All I see are people I've met in other lives, all the paper cranes and the blooming flowers.

#

"Thank you for helping me find her."

The sunset spilled gently across the park, casting long shadows on the worn stone path where the two of us sat. A man with wrinkles as weathered as mine shook his head politely.

"No need to thank me. It was a long, long time ago, but I picked up my daughter from another sleepover at Brightstep. She told me she used to have a friend there who got fostered, and she missed her heavily. I chatted with the coordinator to learn more. She mentioned the name *Maxwell Ken.* At first, I was surprised, but then I doubted it was the same one I met at that train platform ages ago. But only now do I realize—children are a rare sight in our district, aren't they? Of course your daughter would come from Brightstep Fold as well.

"Then the coordinator told me they were preparing to send my daughter's friend to the Japan District, after a family had agreed to adopt her. She gave me the contact and address of the Mizuno family so my daughter could call her friend after dinner. I had written it in my notebook. You're lucky the pages survived, and you're also lucky that I was chosen as a study participant by Dr. Mei before she passed away, and that she told me you were looking for someone. She gave me your number, and I knew I had to call you."

He leaned back on the park bench, gazing toward the towering skyline of Geopolis.

"But that letter you said she wrote," he said, "how did you know it was truly her, and not a poor imitation from the digiarchs?"

"She used an affirmation on the last line. Like a message with a signature at the end."

"I see."

On a distant hill, we watched a child stretch a long strand of bright-colored yarn between trees, benches, and poles, looping it back to its starting point to form a great ring. One by one, other children joined the game by attaching paper messages, clothespins, beads, or tags along the thread.

"When we last met, you asked if my name was supposed to mean something to you. I hope it does now."

The children chose spots around the park next to the thread. When they all worked together to rotate the thread, the trinkets moved along the line, and they intercepted them as they came along. They laughed and giggled at reading each other's messages. Then they placed them back on the thread so they could continue the game.

"Thank you, Rami," I said.

#

"It's people."

"You're right." Dr. Mei's voice on the phone was simultaneously calm and excited. "You were right all along! I figured it out yesterday as well. Come to the lab first thing tomorrow."

I smiled. That's how I imagined our conversation would go.

#

The Pacific District was the largest of all districts, covering over a third of Earth's surface. To find you, I had to cross it—an impossible expanse teeming with languages, customs, and faces I had never known. Who knew what I would see? I could only imagine what I might encounter: subdistricts stacked like geological layers, the smell of grilled synthetic meats at markets, people from every part of Old Earth who migrated an indefinite number of years ago, and stories unfolding in every direction. I imagined myself finding your door, staring up at your apartment, and taking a deep breath. You, running up to my arms, but now we've switched sizes, and you almost topple me over.

I didn't know you yet. You were a stranger in my life, absent from the inner world each of us has called memory. I couldn't explain how quickly that shift occurred, or whether it had even happened at all, only that it had. It left me no choice but to go to you, even if it meant entering a land I had never set foot in.

The journey was impossible without knowing the roads, the trains, the maps, or even the rules of the places I'd go to. But I didn't need to know everything. It was the final, unspoken principle of crowdgaloria: if Geopolis was infinitely dense with people, I could create information in the blink of an eye, through other people who had already walked these paths. That was how we sailed the sea of the unfamiliar: by stitching borrowed memory into our own.

That's why I am not defined as Maxwell Ken, and you are not defined as Claudia Holly.

Because we change every life, we can only be defined by our relationship to each other.

In some lives, we are happy against the weight of the world, and its heaviness centres us like gravity. In others, I'm forced to choose between my health and losing you, and we're falling, drowning, or crying in the same breath. Some lives you are older than me, wrinkles exposed on your face, powerless and vulnerable, and I'm a little child. In others our hearts are burning and we run into the open flame of destiny, victims of the strangeness of people.

In all these lives, our bond is irreplaceable. It is tested against an odyssey of time and space, and we're endlessly reaching or missing someone in this ocean of innumerable strangers, reminding us that individual existence is fragile, but collective existence is forever. Each life feels like one second found against ten thousand years lost. We collide and weave—I pull the silk thread, and you pull it too—our tapestry intertwines and yet, according to physics, we don't resolve the impermanence of memory, but remain creatures made of energy that eat energy, ready to recycle our material back into the world. When two souls are born, what are the odds of bringing them together in a lifetime? What are the odds of them becoming friends? What are the odds of them becoming family? We don't need to explain some things.

Working with Dr. Mei changed my life. I was able to meet you even if we've never met, to pick up the pieces of our time together from nothing. I learned the ways information could be communicated without a transmitter, the importance of memory in maintaining connections, how to say *I love you* without saying it, and just counting on the other person to *know.*

Eras pass forever, time endures nonstop, souls shuffle on and on, but for a brief moment the two of us were able to connect. Against the chaos of the world, even if I am an old man, I want to connect with you one last time before I leave this life and we both get lost again. The Earth is spinning, and I am a colossal figure, looking from the outside. I see the lines and arrays of numberless unyielding people, and I stop the Earth's spin and point to one of them—just a single one of them—no different than any other. There you are. I'm on my way.

It's going to be a long ride.